



PROFESSIONAL MONITORS

This category of monitors is meant for use by imaging and video professionals for whom getting the right colours is of prime importance. The amount of tweaks offered by these monitors, is much higher than your regular everyday use monitors, and they are also priced quite high.

Features

The ASUS ProArt PA246Q comes with a CCFL backlit LCD monitor having a resolution of 1920x1200. You will notice ruler-like markings around the monitor on the bezel but there are no numbers around it. The monitor has a QuickFit button which overlays the screen with centimetre or inches grid or an alignment grid. Apart from these you also get various photo and paper size overlays. The OSD of the PA246Q is similar to the one seen on VS238H but it has some additional features such as Advanced settings which can only be accessed under the Splendid mode named User Settings. Under Advanced settings you can tweak six-axis hue, six-axis saturation levels as well as RGB gain and offset levels, which provides imaging professionals a wider leeway to manipulate colours. It's also the only monitor supporting an SD card reader.

The NEC PA271W also has a CCFL backlight and it is quite hefty in appearance. The OSD menu though is packed to the gills with features. There are shortcut buttons for input port selection and picture-in-picture modes. Surprisingly, it lacks an HDMI port though. You can adjust the black level of the monitor, and can tweak red, yellow, green, cyan, blue and magenta colours under Hue, Saturation and Offset menus. Finally, you have all your eco-friendly set-

tings which also have a carbon footprint calculator. It has an in-built light sensor which adjusts the backlight depending on the brightness of the ambient lighting conditions.

The ViewSonic VP2770 was an interesting monitor in the sense that it supports a 2560x1440 pixel resolution and has a WLED backlighting. Its OSD menu is very similar to the one seen on the VX2770smh. The OSD navigation is using touchscreen buttons on the bottom right corner and they lack any backlight. The OSD menu options are quite basic for a professional grade monitor, specially when you put it beside the in-depth OSD offered by the NEC PA271W and the ASUS PA246Q. For instance in the user colour option under Color Adjust, you just have RGB sliders. It does not have an ambient light sensor.

Build Quality

As far as professional monitors go, the build quality is expected to be top-notch. All three monitors occupy a decent amount of desk space, but we found that Viewsonic VP2770 tends to occupy a much larger base area than the other two monitors thanks to its V-shaped stand. NEC PA271W is the only monitor which has a provision to grip and lift the monitor, but it's also too heavy to be lifted by one hand. Viewsonic VP2770 is the slimmer of the lot thanks to its WLED backlighting as opposed to the CCFL backlighting on the ASUS and NEC monitor. The height adjustment, tilt, swivel, pivot mechanisms on all the monitors is very good. We were surprised to find touch sensitive buttons on the Viewsonic VP2770 and its operational experience isn't as great as the other two monitors.



ASUS PA246Q

Performance

The contrast ratios of the ASUS and NEC monitors was lower than that of the Viewsonic VP2770. This can be attributed to the backlighting – CCFL on the ASUS and NEC monitors and WLED on the Viewsonic one (which allowed it to get a better black luminance levels). The Lagom.nl test results for all the monitors were quite good. The black and white saturation level tests were particularly impressive. In the pixel walk test, only the NEC monitor gave a flicker-free response on all 11 patterns. None of the monitors had any colour shifting issues when viewed from any direction. For HD movie viewing, the ASUS monitor gave the highest score followed by NEC and Viewsonic monitors.

VERDICT 23-inches and under

This segment saw interesting monitors and we were particularly impressed with the NEC E231W which scored highest overall thanks to its impressive feature set, but considering its pricing was prohibitively high for this category, the Best Buy was awarded to BenQ GW 2250. Not only does it cost the lowest, but it had the best performance in this category as well.

24-inches

This category saw the most variety in terms of brands and monitor types. For pure value proposition the award for the Best Buy went to Acer S240HL for its economical pricing whereas it was the third best performer. If pure performance is what you are looking at when considering a 24-inch monitor, the BenQ XL2411T is the monitor to go for if you are interested in gaming.

27-inches and over

The Best Performer was awarded to BenQ GW 2760HS for its very impressive performance scores across all the tests. The contrast ratio offered by this monitor was the best of the lot and it also held its own when it came to HD movie viewing and the battery of Lagom.nl tests we had subjected it to. Since most of the monitors in this category were priced higher than the GW 2760HS, it also ended up winning the Best Buy, as all other monitors gave lower value proposition. LG 29EA93P bagged the Editor's Pick award for its impressive performance, innovative design, in-depth OSD features and for bringing something new to the table in the comparison test. It was also the second best performer in this segment. 